The emperor’s edicts, thus, were a milestone inasmuch as this type of public communication in written form began with him.

The style of the new communication was also highly individualistic. In his stone messages we encounter Ashoka speaking about the several watersheds of his royal life, and through his words we witness how he re-created his own path while trying to remould the lives of people in his empire (as also of those beyond its borders). Candour and emotion, death and decimation, honest admissions and imperious orders are all to be found in the Ashokan edicts. Since his messages were not inscribed all at once but over many years, it becomes possible to examine Ashoka’s persona not as that of a static sovereign but as an evolving emperor of uncommon ambition.

Equally, through these missives on stone Ashoka chose to reach out to his people in, most unusually, the places where they lived and worshipped. By doing so, he literally carved out a subcontinental presence for himself. This is evident to anyone who has followed his trail. One encounters him on rocks and pillars in all kinds of places that formed part of his empire, right across India, Nepal, Pakistan, and Afghanistan. This is because the emperor chose to disseminate his messages by ensuring that his administration sent out multiple copies of them. That he wanted to be heard in the same way in Afghanistan and in Andhra, in Karnataka and in Kalinga, also means that Ashoka’s version of his life and deeds is the one that was likely to have been the best known, certainly during his own lifetime. There is no example, in fact, of an ancient ruler whose voice, in the course of his own life, resonated in such a unique way across South Asia and beyond, articulating the shifting contours of his imperial vision and aspirations. As I said, this is not the only version of his life available to scholars, nor does it permit a complete reconstruction of his life. However, it has the great merit of being what was composed during his rulership, and on his orders.